ASHWINI VAISHNAW, *53* | BJP

Minister of Railways



Civil service stint Vaishnaw finished his school education in Jodhpur, before graduating from MBM Engineering College there with a gold medal in Electronics and Communications. He did his M.Tech. from IIT Kanpur and, in 1994, joined the IAS. Later, he earned an MBA from the Wharton School, US, and left the IAS in 2010 to join the private sector

Political venture In an earlier avatar, Vaishnaw worked in the PMO of Atal Bihari Vajpayee. In 2021, PM Modi handpicked him for a ministerial berth, with key ministries such as Railways, Electronics and Information Technology and Communications. He is a Rajya Sabha member of the BJP from Odisha since 2019

Growing clout Vaishnaw has now been given another **crucial portfolio–Information and Broadcasting**–along with Railways, Electronics and IT. This has only added to his growing prominence in the Modi regime

Ministers of State

RAVNEET SINGH, *48* | BJP



Only ministerial face from Punjab The grandson of ex-Punjab CM Beant Singh finds a place despite losing from Ludhiana. He joined the BJP from the Congress ahead of the LS polls

V. SOMANNA, *73* | BJP



First Union minister from Tumakuru The Veerashaiva-Lingayat leader and first-time LS MP from Tumakuru was a minister in Karnataka. He has roots in the Janata Dal and Congress

EXPERTSPEAK



M. JAMSHED
Former Railway Board Member (Traffic)

"Indian Railways must focus on a capex of over Rs 2.5 lakh crore year-on-year on viable projects to create required infrastructure to carry over 300 MT incremental traffic annually"

ENHANCE EFFICIENCY

Emphasis on digital and mechanised solutions for maintenance will ensure efficient operation of trains like the Vande Bharat Express and the proposed Vande Metro trains. Capacity augmentation will be crucial, freeing up additional paths for passenger trains and improving speed and efficiency. Vande Bharat Sleeper versions are overdue. Station modernisation is crucial, with over 1,300 of them earmarked under the Amrit Bharat branding

NEW REVENUE AVENUES

The freight basket needs to diversify and progressively reduce the Railways' dependency on coal as its biggest breadwinner. Experiments like transportation of white goods and unconventional consignments and enabling last-mile delivery of goods have yielded encouraging results in the past

BULLET TRAINS

This term of the Modi government may also see the rollout of India's first bullet train corridor between Mumbai and Ahmedabad. The government is aiming to start a stretch in the next few years. Uncertainty continues to dog the project due to ups and downs in negotiations with Japanese companies. So, steering it to completion, and on time, will be a challenge. The Railways is eyeing manufacturing its own 'bullet train' that can reach around 250 kmph on the Vande Bharat platform